

Brussels eyes major consolidation of EU research partnerships

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By Martina Sapio · Oct 5, 2026, 6:13 PM · [View in your browser](#)

BRUSSELS — The European Commission is weighing a major shake-up of the EU's research partnerships by consolidating the number of programs, according to an internal Commission document seen by POLITICO.

The document calls for a range of options for the 60 Horizon Europe programs —consolidating them into either 18, 24 or 28 larger groupings for the bloc's next long-term budget.

The partnerships are long-term funding arrangements that bring together the EU, national governments, industry and other organizations to support research considered too costly or complex to pursue alone.

All three restructuring options in the document retain the partnership for road transport research; cleaner aviation and air traffic management would be merged into one. Only the largest plan, with 28 groupings, keeps dedicated areas for both rail and water transport — while the smallest drops both entirely.

The two larger plans also add a new Space and Security area.

Stakeholders were asked to compare the plans in a survey. They were asked which option best supports Europe's long-term research needs, avoids duplication, attracts businesses and other partners, is easiest to manage, can adapt to new developments and would be easiest to adopt. The survey also asked how the partnerships should work together.

The document says the configurations will keep evolving as the Commission gathers more feedback. The process will be presented to the advisory body for EU research ministries on Oct. 12-13; the public consultation closes Oct. 16.

The Commission is aiming to settle on a single proposal by end of the year.

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